25 Heng Mui Keng Terrace, Singapore 119615
Tel: (65) 6516 6960 Fax: (65) 6778 2571
Website: www.iss.nus.edu.sg
Company Registration No: 200604346E

Dear Editor

We are pleased to submit our manuscript entitled "*Where Do Vision Foundation Models Look? A Study of Attention Alignment in Image Recognition*" for consideration in **Pattern Analysis and Applications**.

This manuscript presents an explainable AI study of attention alignment in vision foundation models for image recognition. We examine whether model attention is spatially consistent with human-recognized discriminative evidence, how this alignment varies across transformer layers and heads, and how downstream adaptation changes attention behaviour. We believe the manuscript is well aligned with Pattern Analysis and Applications, which publishes original research on pattern recognition and machine learning. Our work contributes a practical diagnostic framework for interpreting vision foundation models beyond classification accuracy and provides empirical evidence on how different pretraining and adaptation strategies shape attention alignment.

This manuscript is original, has not been published elsewhere, and is not under consideration by another journal. All authors have approved the submission and have no conflicts of interest to declare. The code and data that support the findings of this study are available on the GitHub repository https://github.com/keimiii/xai_viz

Yours sincerely,
TIAN Jing (Ph.D.)
Principal Lecturer, Artificial Intelligence Practice
NUS-ISS, National University of Singapore
Email: tianjing@nus.edu.sg